Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Services in Toronto: Methodology

November 6, 2026

Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Services in Toronto: Methodology

Research Methodology

This study will use a qualitative methodology to explore how newcomer families at one Toronto child care centre learn about, access, and use or do not use the family support services that the centre offers or refers them to. Qualitative research explores a central phenomenon in depth through the detailed accounts of a small number of participants (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Depth is required because the study asks how families move from first hearing about a service to deciding whether to use it. A count of fee subsidy applications could show that some families never applied, but it could not show what they understood, who helped them, or why they stopped at a particular step. Only parents' own detailed accounts can trace that process.

Context is the second reason. Qualitative researchers give close attention to the context in which participants' experiences take place (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, that context includes how the centre shared information, in which language, which referrals were made, and what an application asked for. Each family meets these conditions with its own language, work schedule, and settlement history, so they differ even within one centre. Because context is carried in what parents report, it does not depend on where the interview is held, and an interview on Zoom or by phone can capture it as fully as one at the centre.

The third reason is meaning-making. Qualitative research seeks to understand how people make meaning of their social realities (Mwita, 2022). Services are usually designed and explained from the provider's side, and parents' own interpretations can be left out. A term such as eligibility or waitlist may mean something different to a parent than to an educator. If the study fixed in advance what counts as a barrier or as help, it could miss what families see as important. Open-ended questions will let parents define what helped, what confused them, and what a service meant to their family.

Research Design

The study will follow a qualitative descriptive design. Qualitative description aims to produce a comprehensive summary of events in the everyday terms of the people who experienced them, and its interpretation stays close to the data (Sandelowski, 2000). In keeping with this low level of inference, the interviews will be analyzed with thematic analysis at the semantic level, which codes what participants explicitly say (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

This design will make the study easier to carry out in ways that answer the research question. First, it lets the interviews and findings follow the order in which families encountered a service. Because qualitative description reports events in participants' own terms (Sandelowski, 2000), the interview protocol can move step by step through hearing about a service, understanding its requirements, seeking help, and deciding whether to use it. The findings can be organized along the same steps, so each one answers part of the question about what helped or limited families and how the centre responded. Second, the design suits studies that need information directly from the people affected and that have limited time and resources (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). With four interviews in Weeks 2 to 4 and the findings report due in Week 7, one round of interviews keeps the project feasible. Third, findings close to participants' words can inform practice (Villamin et al., 2025), showing educators which explanations and referrals helped families.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

The participants will be four newcomer parents or primary caregivers. In this study, a newcomer family is an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be 18 or older, (b) have arrived in Canada within the past five years, (c) have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the centre in

the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON programs, or settlement services, and (e) be able to take part in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

These criteria select parents with direct and recent experience of accessing the services the research question asks about. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they used the service, because the question covers both. Each account will be explored on its own terms, and families will not be divided into users and non-users or compared.

Three groups will be excluded. The first is families I worked with directly during my field placement, since a parent who knows me as their child's educator may find it hard to refuse or to criticize the centre (Villamin et al., 2025). The second is centre staff and their family members, whose employment could create pressure to take part or to speak positively. The third is parents who already hold Canadian citizenship. Citizenship removes the status-based eligibility rules that newcomers may meet when applying for services, and it usually reflects a longer settlement period than this study explores. Permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, and people on work or study permits will be included, because each status carries different eligibility rules that shape families' experiences.

Screening will ask only when the parent arrived in Canada and whether they hold citizenship. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that undocumented families often cannot provide (Schmidt, 2026), so broader questions about status could discourage families from joining.

Recruitment Setting

Participants will be recruited from a licensed child care centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, where I completed my field placement. To protect families' privacy, the centre will not be named in this proposal or in any report. The centre already shares information about family support services and refers families to them. Toronto's service plan also names child care settings as access points and identifies tax-filing requirements as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025). My placement gives me access to the centre, which makes recruitment feasible within the course timeline.

Recruitment Methods

The first step will be to obtain approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and written permission from the centre director. No family will be contacted before both are in place. I will then prepare a one-page flyer and a letter of information in plain English and translate them into Mandarin and other languages common at the centre. The materials will explain the purpose of the study, the total time of about 60 to 75 minutes in one meeting, the voluntary nature of taking part, the $25 gift card, and how to reach me.

The $25 gift card recognizes the 60 to 75 minutes the meeting asks of each parent. The Tri-Council Policy Statement asks researchers to weigh incentives against participants' economic circumstances so that they do not become undue inducements (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022). Head (2009) also discusses how payment in qualitative research can recognize participants' time while raising concerns about undue influence on consent. A modest $25 card thanks families without overriding their judgment about joining. Parents will receive it at the start of the meeting and keep it even if they withdraw, and the Research Ethics Board will review the amount.

The director will share the invitation through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and family cubbies, and staff will not approach families in person. As in Hardware et al. (2026), someone other than the lead researcher will distribute the invitation to avoid a conflict of interest. Because a notice from the director could still feel like a request from the centre, the flyer will state that the centre will not know who takes part and that the decision will not affect any child's care. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, these are newcomer parents to whom the centre has given information about, or a

referral to, a family support service. The sample will also be a convenience sample of willing and available parents at a centre I can already reach (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The purposive criteria decide who is eligible, and convenience explains where they will be found.

Participant Selection. Interested parents will contact me directly by email, phone, or text, and I will screen each one in a 10-minute call against the inclusion and exclusion criteria. The centre will take no part in screening or selection, so it will not learn who responded. Eligible parents will receive the letter of information and consent form in their preferred language and will have at least 48 hours to decide. The first four eligible parents who agree will form the sample, with one adult per family. Others will be offered a place on a waitlist and invited in turn if a participant withdraws before the interview. Selection in order of contact is a practical choice, and because it may favour parents who respond quickly, this limit will be noted in the findings.

Sample Size. The study will include four participants. Qualitative studies commonly use about four to eight participants so that the researcher can explore each person's experience in detail (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Four participants also match the course requirement for individual projects. The findings will describe these four families' experiences and will not be generalized to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

Data will be collected through individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews. The interview is my data collection method, and an interview protocol is my tool. The protocol will list open-ended questions with follow-up probes, and its flexible order will let me ask for more detail when a parent raises something new. Individual interviews suit this study better than focus groups because income and subsidy are sensitive topics and families at one centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025). Before Week 1, the protocol will be piloted with one newcomer parent from outside the study to check its wording, translation, and length.

Each participant will take part in one meeting of about 60 to 75 minutes at a time the family chooses. Families can meet in a private room at the centre outside drop-off and pick-up

times, on Zoom, or by phone. Those who join online may turn off the camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I will interview Mandarin speakers myself. For other languages, a trained interpreter who signs a confidentiality agreement will join, so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). Each meeting will follow three steps:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will go through the letter of information in the parent's language and answer any questions. The parent will then sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent and receive the $25 gift card.
2. **Background form (about 5 minutes).** The parent will note years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and the services the centre shared or referred. The form will not ask about immigration category or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** With permission, I will audio record the interview. The questions will follow the steps families take toward a service. Parents will describe how they learned about a service, what they understood about eligibility and applying, and who helped them, such as educators, settlement workers, or relatives. They will explain what led them to use or not use the service. Finally, they will describe whether they could raise needs linked to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would suggest the centre change. At the end, each parent will receive a list of community supports such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Taking part is voluntary. Parents may skip any question or stop the interview at any time and will still keep the gift card. They may withdraw their data within one week after their interview, before I begin coding it, and their child's care will not be affected either way. Names will be replaced with pseudonyms, and recordings and transcripts will be kept in encrypted, password-protected files stored apart from the consent forms. Only I will hold the list that links pseudonyms to names. A small sample from one centre can make people identifiable, so my reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language. Any quotation that could identify a family will also be changed or left out (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Obtain ethics approval and the director's permission, translate materials, and pilot the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Share the invitation, send one reminder if needed, screen parents, obtain consent, and schedule interviews
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	Begin interviews in Week 2, complete at least three of four (75%) by the end of Week 3, and transcribe each one soon after it ends
Week 4	Complete data collection	Conduct the last interview and begin initial coding
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Submit a summary of preliminary findings
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Complete semantic thematic analysis and submit the findings report by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Review and refine the findings using feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Complete a draft of the presentation
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Revise the presentation and the final report
Week 14	Final submission	Submit the final report

Ethics approval must be in place before the term begins, because recruitment starts in Week 1 and interviews begin in Week 2. Each interview will be transcribed soon after it ends, and coding will start in Week 4, so the preliminary findings will be ready in Week 5. Throughout the study, I will record decisions, changes, and challenges in my reflexive journal.

References

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2022). *Thematic analysis: A practical guide*. SAGE.

Canadian Institutes of Health Research, Natural Sciences and Engineering Research Council of Canada, & Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada. (2022). *Tri-Council policy statement: Ethical conduct for research involving humans – TCPS 2 (2022)*. https://ethics.gc.ca/eng/policy-politique_tcps2-eptc2_2022.html

Creswell, J. W., & Guetterman, T. C. (2019). *Educational research: Planning, conducting, and evaluating quantitative and qualitative research* (6th ed.). Pearson.

Hall, S., & Liebenberg, L. (2024). Qualitative description as an introductory method to qualitative research for master's-level students and research trainees. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods, 23*. https://doi.org/10.1177/16094069241242264

Hardware, S., Quiogue, C., Gallo, M., & Avis, M. (2026). Let's talk about race: The use of virtual reality in improving higher education students' understanding of privilege. *Teaching & Learning Inquiry, 14*, 1–22. https://doi.org/10.20343/teachlearninqu.14.33

Head, E. (2009). The ethics and implications of paying participants in qualitative research. *International Journal of Social Research Methodology, 12*(4), 335–344.

Ilumin, P. (2023). *Defining quality in early learning and childcare among visible cultural minority families in Edmonton, Alberta* [Master's thesis, University of Alberta]. ERA. https://ualberta.scholaris.ca/items/0eb08257-1405-4722-a251-5fa8f989c99f

Massing, C., Gyan, C., Giesbrecht, C. J., Kikulwe, D., & Ghadi, N. (2024). Preferences and challenges in access to childcare programs: A mixed-methods study with newcomers to Canada. *International Journal of Early Childhood, 56*(3), 421–441. https://doi.org/10.1007/s13158-023-00375-w

Mwita, K. M. (2022). Strengths and weaknesses of qualitative research in social science studies. *International Journal of Research in Business and Social Science, 11*(6), 618–625. https://doi.org/10.20525/ijrbs.v11i6.1920

Sandelowski, M. (2000). Whatever happened to qualitative description? *Research in Nursing & Health*, *23*(4), 334–340. https://doi.org/10.1002/1098-240X(200008)23:4<334::AID-NUR9>3.0.CO;2-G

Schmidt, C. (2026). The bordering of care: How exclusions from family support programs impact undocumented mothers and their young children in Canada. *Critical Social Policy*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1177/02610183261460334

Toronto Children's Services. (2025). *Early years and child care service plan 2025–2030*. City of Toronto. https://www.toronto.ca/legdocs/mmis/2025/ec/bgrd/backgroundfile-256726.pdf

Villamin, P., Lopez, V., Thapa, D. K., & Cleary, M. (2025). A worked example of qualitative descriptive design: A step-by-step guide for novice and early career researchers. *Journal of Advanced Nursing*, *81*, 5181–5195. https://doi.org/10.1111/jan.16481